50TH ANNIVERSARY

POLITICS
1995-2005



SITARAM KESRI

BHASKAR PAUL



| THE KINGMAKER |

GAME OF THRONES

Sitaram Kesri, backroom badshah and emblem of power without responsibility, was just a device. Through his caprices, a federal polity was being birthed

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History would judge Narasimha Rao differently for what he did to the nation, but the Congress as a party atrophied during his reign. It still struggles to shed the diminution of stature it suffered then, as the BJP rose under charismatic leaders like L.K. Advani and A.B. Vajpayee. As Rao left the stage, Sonia Gandhi had not fully emerged from the sphinx-like solitude of 10, Janpath. The one who took the wheel was Sitaram Kesri, an old-style apparatchik who ticked all the boxes for the stereotypical *neta*: wily, scheming, more comfy in the backroom or on the white *gaddas* spread out for Congress Working Committee *baithaks* than out in the sunlight.

Such a man became the arbiter of everyone's fate for two years, and the legacy he left behind still haunts his party: if potential partners still harbour doubts at the Congress's trustworthiness, it owes to those two stormy years when Kesri seated and unseated two governments. Too clever by half, he cleared the rubble for the BJP. The Janata parivar, too, was the opposite